

THE REAL Ms UNIVERSE

■ By Raj Chengappa

In a country that believes that beauty trophies are a genetic right, they are calling her the true Miss Universe. But when she strides into the room with her deep blue space overalls, dark sports shoes, a haversack slung across her broad shoulders and her lined face devoid of make-up, it is apparent she makes no effort to be the role model for models. Williams even modestly flicks away the crown saying: "I think a citizen of the universe is a lot better than a 'Miss.' I have been trying to get across to people who haven't been up in space that we are citizens of a bigger place than just our planet."

There is not, however, another woman on earth who has achieved

"Up in space, the Gita and Ganesha were what kept me grounded. They put life in perspective."



quite what Sunita Williams has in the past year. As a female astronaut, she holds the record for the longest space flight (195 days), the highest number of spacewalks (four) and the maximum time spent on spacewalks (29 hours and 17 minutes). On her first visit to India after her record breaking space odyssey, Williams, whose father, Deepak Pandya originally hailed from Gujarat, wowed audiences across the country with details of her experiences at the International Space Station (ISS).

As she settles down for an exclusive interview with INDIA TODAY in Delhi, it is soon apparent that Williams is a woman of much substance and extraordinary courage. Like Moses returning from Mount Sinai full of godly wisdom, Williams's experience in space has radically altered her perspective of life. From 350 km in orbit, the earth appears a magnificently beautiful whole. She says: "It is hard to



EPIC JOURNEY:
Williams's space tour
broke many records

Photograph by SANDEEP SINGH